



Entry Criteria VS Exit Criteria

The Gatekeepers

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TL;DR

Entry Criteria: The requirements that must be met **before** testing can begin (The "Start" Line).

Exit Criteria: The requirements that must be met **before** testing can stop (The "Finish" Line).

The Core Concept

Testing is expensive. We shouldn't start until we are ready, and we shouldn't stop until we are safe. These criteria act as **Gatekeepers** for the testing phase.

🟢 Entry Criteria (When to Start)

- "Is the environment ready?"
- "Is the code installed?"
- "Do we have valid login credentials?"
- *If these are NO, we do not start testing.*

🔴 Exit Criteria (When to Stop)

- "Did we run all the tests?"
 - "Are all Critical bugs fixed?"
 - "Did we meet the deadline?"
 - *If these are NO, we cannot release the product.*
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✈️ The Flight Analogy

Entry Criteria (Takeoff):

Before a pilot takes off, specific things must happen:

- Fuel tank full? ✅
- Doors closed? ✅
- Runway clear? ✅

If the doors are open, the plane does not move.

Exit Criteria (Landing):

Before the flight is considered "Complete," specific things must happen:

- Wheels down? ✅

- Plane stopped at the gate? ✅
- Seatbelt sign off? ✅

You cannot let passengers out while the plane is still moving.

The Checklist

Common Entry Criteria (Inputs):

1. Requirement Documents are signed off.
2. Test Plan is written and approved.
3. Test Data (User accounts) is created.
4. The Build is deployed to the QA Environment.
5. Smoke Test passed (The build isn't crashing).

Common Exit Criteria (Outputs):

1. 100% of High Priority Test Cases passed.
 2. Zero "Showstopper" or "Critical" bugs open.
 3. Code Coverage is above 80% (if applicable).
 4. Test Summary Report is written.
 5. UAT (User Acceptance Testing) sign-off.
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Real World Example: The "Checkout" Feature

Phase: System Testing

Entry Check Failed:

The developer says "The code is ready," but when I try to log in, the database is down.

Action: I block testing. I cannot test "Checkout" if I cannot even log in. **Entry Criteria not met.**

✅ Exit Check Passed:

We ran 50 tests. 48 Passed. 2 Failed.

The 2 failures are cosmetic (typos). All Critical payments worked.

Action: We decide the quality is good enough to release. **Exit Criteria met.**

🧠 Why This Matters

Entry Criteria saves me time. I don't waste 3 hours testing a broken build.

Exit Criteria saves the company reputation. It prevents us from releasing a product simply because "We ran out of time." We release only when the *Quality* says so.